

wire (USB 2.0 / USB 3.0) attached to the drive. These drives can get a bit uneasy to use. Always make sure that the interface wire is separate from the drive body.

Specs that don't matter

Speed

Only if you are looking at high capacity drives, there is no point looking at the speeds. So long as the external drive houses even a 5400 RPM drive, you are good to go.

Cloud Storage

While a good feature to have, this should not be a criterion for selecting an external drive. You have your Dropboxes and Google Drives of the world for cloud storage.

Recommendations

Very high capacity

There are a lot of 3 TB drives on the market. We personally like the Seagate Backup Plus which along with decent speeds and economical cost per GB, also gives you the option to backup your data from social networking sites such as Facebook, Flickr and YouTube.

NAS Drive

The Western Digital 4 TB drive is the one you should be looking at if you want a huge capacity NAS drive. It has two, 2 TB drives which come in a RAID 0 configuration by default. The Seagate Satellite drive is another interesting option, which houses a Wi-Fi radio within it and can be used as extended storage for your tablets and smartphones. Using an app, content from the Seagate Satellite can be accessed by your mobile devices.

High-speed drives

The Hitachi Mobile Touro drives sport 7200 RPM internal drives, so they offer fabulous speeds when compared with their counterparts. These drives are ideal for professionals who value speed over capacity.



Solid State Drives (SSD) have become quite popular these days with system builders, thanks to their extremely fast access times and brilliant transfer speeds. Pairing a low capacity SSD with a high capacity HDD is something that is being seen quite often these days. So you have your operating system and some heavy applications such as Photoshop on the SSD and other data on the slower HDD. This makes the system run faster and heavy programs load faster. So what are the points to be considered before getting an SSD? Read on...

Specs that matter

Usage

This is one of the main reasons to ponder over before making that SSD purchase. Are you looking for just a boot drive or a boot drive with enough space for storing your most frequently used programs or the SSD will be the only drive in your

system? Once you are decided on this, then things become easier. Also keep in mind your budget. SSDs these days start from as low as ₹4,000 and can go all the way well over the mid-range PC-rig budget. Lower capacity will not necessarily mean lower prices as many SSD manufacturers have a series of SSDs for different categories of users.

Controller support

Controllers are the hearts of SSDs which are otherwise just a collection of flash NAND memories. It's the SSD controller which decides which data goes where and how to optimally access data from various NAND memory chips. Last year and over the major portion of this year, we saw the majority of SSD makers opting for the SandForce based controllers, which gave great speeds. In the coming months, there will be many more controllers which will see the light of the day. It's pertinent for you to check which controller your drive will support before getting the drive. Read up on that particular controller. You do not want to spend money on an SSD drive just to realise that it has some crappy controller which will not give optimum performance. The SandForce SF2281 controller is quite the popular controller. But two SSDs with this same controller may give a different performance.

Types of memory

The NAND memory chips that you see on SSDs can be of three types: Synchronous, Asynchronous and Toggle mode NAND. From a consumer's perspective, asynchronous NAND memory is the comparatively cheaper memory as compared to the more expensive synchronous memory.

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